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Seminar:

“Mama, Welcome To the 60s”:

Nostalgia and Change in *Hairspray*(1988) and *Hairspray*(2007)

Nostalgia, Retro and Memory in Television and Cinema in Israel and the USA

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“Mama, Welcome To the 60s”:

Nostalgia and Change in *Hairspray* (1988) and *Hairspray* (2007)

Introduction

Our memory, like cinema, is shaped by our desires, our current reality, and ideology. In our cultural landscape, nostalgia functions not just as a longing for the past, but as an active reconstruction of history designed to soothe, to provoke, or to make sense of the present. Film, as one of the most potent tools of collective memory, becomes a key for exploring how societies imagine their pasts- and more crucially, what they choose to forget or change. Within this framework, the musical film *Hairspray* exists as a rich example for examining how nostalgia is used and transformed across decades. The 1988 version of *Hairspray*, directed by John Waters, and its 2007 remake, directed by Adam Shankman, both revisit the same narrative setting (early 1960s Baltimore) but do so through different political lenses, aesthetic strategies, and ideological intentions. This seminar interrogates not just the films themselves, but the cultural and historical moments in which they were produced, asking: What does it mean to nostalgically remember the 1960s in the conservative President Regan policies of the 1980s versus the post- 9/11 2000s? What gets included in these memories, and what is left out?

Rather than offering a comparison between the two films, this study proposes that *Hairspray* (1988) and *Hairspray* (2007) represent two opposing tendencies of the use of nostalgia in contemporary cinema. Waters’ original *Hairspray* is steeped in camp aesthetics and satirical irreverence, presenting nostalgia as something to be critiqued and deconstructed, a mechanism through which dominant historical narratives are exposed or unraveled. Its vision of the 1960s is uncomfortable, exaggerated, and unpolished- a reflection of the director’s tweaking of mainstream memory and his challenge to a Reagan- era resurgence of a sanitized Americana. Through his use of “tacky drag,” low-budget aesthetics, and queer subtext, Waters resists the hegemonic forces that often smooth over the past in favor of nationalist myth. His 1960s is not the pristine, progressive decade enshrined in liberal memory, but a chaotic and contradictory space

where race, class, gender, and fame are constantly at odds. In contrast, Shankman's 2007 *Hairspray* capitalizes on Broadway spectacle and optimistic, feel-good musical conventions, offering a polished take on history that turns civil rights into choreography and systemic injustice into narrative resolution. The very texture of the 2007 film, from its glittery musical numbers to its neat resolutions, functions to repackage the past as palatable and emotionally uplifting.

This exploration is particularly important when considering how the media participates in the myth-making of racial integration and civil rights history. In both films, we find the archetype of the white savior- Tracy Turnblad- who becomes the unlikely agent of social change, dancing her way into racial justice despite being a teenage girl. Yet, the way this trope functions shifts between the two versions. In Waters' version, Tracy's heroism is satirized and layered in irony, framed as both a parody of white liberal benevolence and a sincere attempt at representation. In the 2007 film, however, the satire is stripped away. Tracy's centrality becomes earnest, even celebratory, and her role as the agent of integration becomes a digestible, and ultimately depoliticized narrative. The black characters, particularly Motormouth Maybelle, are sidelined from the position of leadership. While Waters' Tracy functions almost as an ironic device- a good white liberal who is just as much a product of the media she consumes as she is a sincere activist- Shankman's Tracy becomes a beacon of moral clarity. The effect is not insignificant: it shifts the cultural work of memory from questioning white complicity to reassuring white viewers of their place on the right side of history. What is lost in this translation from satire to spectacle is a sense of struggle- the hard, violent, systemic work of organizing and resisting. Instead, we get a version of history that sings and dances its way to resolution. Stripped of political messiness, the civil rights movement becomes a flattened montage of smiling faces and seamless integration, made safe for audiences hungry for unity over discomfort.

What's at stake in these portrayals is not just the representation of the past, but our understanding of the present. *Hairspray (2007)*, emerging in an era of "post-racial" rhetoric and growing neoliberal optimism, trades in exactly this kind of narrative. It converts the 1960s into a time of

vibrant moral clarity and inevitable progress, sidestepping the messiness of racialized violence. In contrast, *Hairspray* (1988) insists on that messiness, using satire not as an escape, but as an entry point into deeper critique. Through its tacky aesthetics and grotesque drag performances, it resists the conservative impulses of restorative nostalgia and instead embraces a reflective nostalgia- one that is fragmented, conflicted, and rooted in the awareness that the past can never be fully recaptured. It forces its audience to sit with discomfort and to recognize that the narratives we tell ourselves about progress and justice are as constructed as the hairdos on screen.

In doing so, Waters' *Hairspray* becomes more than a period piece. It becomes a challenge to the audience to remember differently- to interrogate the “good old days” and ask whose stories were excluded from the mainstream imagination. Shankman's remake, while undeniably entertaining and culturally impactful, does the opposite: it provides comfort, resolution, and harmony. It turns civil rights into a musical number and revolution into a dance. It transforms social justice from a collective, often painful process into something light and digestible. In a world increasingly reliant on aestheticized versions of activism, such portrayals have profound implications for how history is learned and commodified. Both of these films offer us not just narratives, but frameworks for understanding change, justice, and progress.

This seminar, then, is less about determining which version of *Hairspray* is more accurate or effective, and more about tracing the ideology of how nostalgia operates within each film version. By unpacking the aesthetic choices, musical forms, character dynamics, and narrative resolutions of the 1988 and 2007 films, we understand how cinema functions as a tool of memory and myth. We also reveal how historical moments (such as the conservatism of the 1980s or the post- 9/11 liberalism of the 2000s) shape not only what we remember, but how we remember. Whether as critique or comfort, irony or optimism, both versions of *Hairspray* tell us something profound about the relationship between culture, history, and identity.

Theoretical Framework of Nostalgia in Film

To understand how *Hairspray* (1988) and *Hairspray* (2007) construct their versions of the 1960s, it is essential to engage with theories of nostalgia and cinematic representation. Nostalgia in film is not just a longing for a past era but a process of reconstructing history to serve contemporary cultural and ideological needs or beliefs. As Andrew Higson argues, nostalgia is a "multi-layered, diversely experienced, and variously exploited" phenomenon that operates differently depending on contexts. (Higson 120) Nostalgia is not a static emotion or connection but rather a fluid concept, shaped by an evolving relationship between the past and the present.

Whether cinematic nostalgia serves as a form of historical critique or as an aestheticized or depoliticized representation of the past is up for debate. Fredric Jameson characterizes nostalgia films in postmodern times as a mode that "[conveys] 'pastness' by the glossy qualities of the image." (Jameson 64) From this perspective, *Hairspray* (2007), with its polished musical numbers and broad appeal might exemplify this postmodern approach, in contrast to John Waters' 1988 version, which employs camp and satire to critically engage with historical memory. While both films look back at the same decade (that being the 1960s), they do so with different aesthetic and narrative choices that shape how the audience perceives both the past and the present.

Higson expands on this idea, noting that postmodern nostalgia often "flattens out" the difference between past and present making the past feel contemporaneous rather than distant. (Higson 120-1) This flattening effect is crucial because it creates a sense of continuity, blurring the lines between eras, and preventing the audience from fully engaging with the temporal distance of the past.

In the contemporary period, nostalgia is a heavily mediated experience, manifested in the intense public recycling of narratives, images, sounds, characters and styles (Higson 121)

This constant recycling is not just a passive process but a deliberate construction, often curated by media producers to evoke specific emotional responses and reinforce societal norms. This concept is particularly relevant when comparing the two *Hairspray* films. The 1988 version presents the

1960s through an ironic lens, actively questioning the mainstream, sanitized visions of the era, whereas the 2007 adaptation transforms the same historical moment into a feel-good, celebratory musical, reinforcing rather than deconstructing its nostalgic appeal. In this way, the films act as two sides of the same coin: one as a critique of nostalgia's ability to sanitize history, and the other as a celebration of its capacity to comfort and unite. This can be exemplified by the opening of each film. The 1988 version opens with the "Corny Collins Show", a teen dance show. The teen dancers, who are all sporting 1960s styled beehive hair, spray their tall hair and dance as they wait for the show to begin. The ironic hair spraying of hair that is already stiff introduces the absurdity of this 1960s landscape. The 2007 version of *Hairspray* opens up with the musical number: "Good Morning Baltimore" sung by the lead- Tracey Turnblat. A plus sized white teenager. She sings about her love for Baltimore as she describes the less appealing aspects of it with joy: "The rats on the street all dance round my feet. They seem to say: Tracy, it's up to you!" Although there is a certain irony to it- it still does aestheticize the 1960s. The shots are bright, hopeful, and look slightly up at Tracey. After Tracey continues to sing: "There's the flasher who lives next door, there's the bum on his bar room stool, they wish me luck on my way to school," the camera zooms out revealing Tracey on a beautiful Baltimore street singing and dancing joyously.

Slavoj Žižek offers a different approach, framing nostalgia as an ideological tool that masks present anxieties. In "Looking Awry," Žižek discusses how the media can use nostalgia to create a comforting but misleading representation of the historical past. "Instead of transposing a fragment of the past into a timeless, mythic present, we view the present itself as if it were part of the mythic past." (Žižek 70) Žižek's theory suggests that nostalgia can function as a coping mechanism, a way for societies to escape the complexities or uncertainties of the present by simplifying the past. Using the film *Body Heat* as an example, he notes: "If we do not take into consideration this 'gaze of the '40s,' *Body Heat* remains simply a contemporary film about contemporary times and, as such, totally incomprehensible." (Žižek 70) By projecting the past into the present, nostalgia distorts our understanding of both.

The ideological function of nostalgia is evident in *Hairspray* (2007), which, despite addressing racial integration, smooths over the historical tensions of the 1960s, presenting a more harmonious vision of progress than what was actually experienced. In doing so, it creates a comforting vision of social change, one that reaffirms the notion of inevitable progress and downplays the struggles and contradictions of the civil rights movement.

In contrast, *Hairspray* (1988) embraces a more subversive mode of nostalgia. Waters' use of camp and satire disrupts conventional nostalgic frameworks, making visible the absurdity of social norms in both the 1960s and the 1980s. Waters' approach is intentionally uncomfortable and disruptive, forcing the audience to confront the contradictions and absurdities of both past and present societal values. This aligns with what Paul Frosh describes as "reflective nostalgia," which suggests that nostalgia can be used not only to romanticize the past but also to reflect on and critique present social conditions.

Opposed to 'restorative nostalgia', which involves a clear-cut desire to replace the present with the past, reflective nostalgia permits perceptual and emotional conflicts and contradictions, and suggests critical ways of 'inhabiting many places at once and imagining different time zones'. Where restorative nostalgia promotes the homogeneity and regression of the self, reflective nostalgia offers multiplicity and, perhaps, growth.
(Frosh 788)

Frosh's definition emphasizes how reflective nostalgia invites audiences to engage with the past in a way that encourages awareness, rather than simply offering escapism or a return to a supposedly simpler time. Frosh further complicates our understanding of nostalgia by exploring how media globalization allows audiences to experience nostalgia for a past that is not their own. (Frosh 785) In today's interconnected world, nostalgia can be commodified and spread across borders, offering a universalized version of history that may resonate with people from diverse backgrounds. This idea is relevant to the reception of *Hairspray* (2007), which, as a Hollywood blockbuster, portrays a version of 1960s America that can be consumed globally, reinforcing a

universalized vision of progress. By contrast, *Hairspray* (1988), with its independent film aesthetics and campy humor, perhaps invites its audience to engage critically with its historical representation.

Historical and Sociopolitical Context

Both of the films, *Hairspray* (1988) and *Hairspray* (2007), are set in 1960s Baltimore, a period of significant social change in the United States, particularly regarding civil rights and social norms. However, their production contexts—1988 and 2007—significantly shaped how they reconstruct this past of 1960s Baltimore. While both films depict racial integration in a teen dance show, their portrayals of civil rights and activism reflect the cultural and political discourses of their respective eras. The way each film constructs this era is not a reflection of the 1960s but a product of the cultural and political climate of the time in which it was made, influencing how themes of race and social change are represented and engaged with.

John Waters' *Hairspray* (1988) was released at the end of Ronald Reagan's presidency, a period characterized by conservative Republican politics and a renewed nostalgia for the 1950s and early 1960s. As Andrew Higson suggests, nostalgia can function as a form of conservative response to change, offering "patriotic escapism." (Higson 122) The 1980s were marked by a resurgence of "traditional" values, often reframed as part of a "return" to an idealized past, offering comfort amid social upheavals. The Reagan era saw a romanticized revival of 1950s American values, often sidestepping the racial and social struggles of the time (Ferrari 19). This nostalgic lens positioned the 1950s as a utopian moment, while ignoring the complex realities of racial inequality, gender roles, and the burgeoning LGBTQ rights movement.

The ethos of the Fifties was weaponized by the political discourse of the Eighties. This political strategy aimed at the erasure of the civil rights victories of the 1960s and 1970s, conveniently forgetting the steps forward made by women, people of color, and the LGBTQ community, in order to promote an unreal portrait of Americanness which did not include minorities. This cultural shift was mainly caused by the rhetoric of Ronald Reagan. (Ferrari 22)

The erasure of these historical advancements in the cultural memory, as discussed by Ferrari, allowed for the construction of a sanitized American identity and history that ignored the complexities of race and class struggles, reinforcing an exclusionary political agenda.

Waters' film directly subverts this nostalgia, using camp and satire to challenge the idea that the early 1960s were a period of innocence or social harmony. In contrast to dominant cultural narratives that downplayed the racial tensions of the civil rights era, *Hairspray* (1988) presents a world where racial integration is met with resistance, but ultimately, it is young people—led by Tracy Turnblad—who break down these barriers through music and dance. By doing so, Waters creates a counter narrative, one where youth and music are positioned as forces for social change, offering a more complex view of racial integration. However, even Waters' version simplifies historical realities by framing integration as primarily a cultural movement rather than a deeply political struggle. The real-life protests that inspired the film, such as those against *The Buddy Deane Show*, did not resolve as neatly as *Hairspray* suggests. Instead, after the actual interracial broadcast of *The Buddy Deane Show*, the station received bomb threats and hate mail, leading to the show's cancellation rather than its integration. (Plant 10) This stark contrast between historical events and the film's representation underscores the tension between films' tendency to simplify history for entertainment or narrative purposes and the reality of political resistance and backlash during the civil rights era.

By contrast, *Hairspray* (2007) emerged in a post- 9/11 United States of America, a time when mainstream media increasingly embraced messages of diversity and inclusion. However, as Alex Plant argues, the film presents a depoliticized version of the civil rights movement. Produced against the backdrop of the War on Terror and the rise of global activism, *Hairspray* (2007) echoes broader social movements of the early 21st century, but distills the complexities of racial integration into a feel-good narrative that aligns with the prevailing cultural optimism of the time. Unlike the 1988 film, which employs irony and satire to critique racial attitudes, the 2007 version

frames integration as an inevitable and joyous process, largely devoid of struggle or systemic resistance.

The New York Times comments “That *Hairspray* cheerfully conflates racial prejudice with fat-phobia is the measure of its guileless, deliberately simplified politics.” But it is these “simplified” politics which disregard the historical traditions of the institution of racism. (Plant 5)

In reducing racial prejudice to a simplistic, broad issue, the 2007 film fails to acknowledge the nuances and complexities of racism, particularly within the socio-political context of the 1960s, where institutional and systemic racism were entrenched. Plant critiques the film for perpetuating a white- centered narrative of civil rights, where Tracy- a white teenager- becomes the movement’s figurehead while Black characters remain largely passive. The film’s protest march, for instance, is initiated by Tracy rather than any of the other black characters, reinforcing the trope of a white savior leading Black activists. Additionally, the film’s conclusion suggests that integration is achieved simply by removing two racist individuals (Velma and Amber), ignoring the structural realities of segregation and racism. (Plant 8-9) By presenting the civil rights movement as a victory achieved through the actions of a few individual heroes, the 2007 film simplifies the ongoing challenges of racial inequality, implying that social progress is a matter of good intentions rather than systemic change.

Although [the 2007 version of *Hairspray*] may be less violent and the racism less overt, Shankman’s *Hairspray* relies on stereotypes from the white perspective both in the depiction of African American characters and the Civil Rights Movement as a whole. By perpetuating this white narrative of the Civil Rights movement, *Hairspray*’s portrayal of this key moment in history not only devalues African Americans as agents of change, but attempts to validate stereotypes and misrepresents black identity as purely cosmetic. (Plant 1)

This critique underlines how the film's narrative reduces African American identity to surface-level representation, using it as a backdrop to the white protagonist's journey of self-discovery, rather than engaging with the true political and social struggles of the time.

Identity In *Hairspray*

As discussed, one of the most significant themes in *Hairspray* is racial integration, particularly how Tracy Turnblad, a white protagonist, becomes involved in the civil rights movement through her love of music and dance. However, the treatment of race and gender differs considerably between the two versions. John Waters' *Hairspray* (1988) uses satire to critique the racial hypocrisy of the 1960s. While the film presents integration as inevitable, it also exposes the absurdity of segregation by highlighting the artificiality of mainstream television and pop culture. The film's exaggerated aesthetic, including over the top hairdos and dance moves, serves as a parody of both 1960s America and the 1980s nostalgia for the era. From the opening of the 1988 *Hairspray*, we can see the exaggerated use of 1960s aesthetics. A minute into the opening, we see a dancer on the Corny Collins show spray her beehive hairdo with an exaggerated amount of hairspray. Further into the opening, we see a young couple touching each other's bouncy hair as they take turns spraying each other's hair lovingly with hairspray. The music of the opening number exaggerates this further. The lyrics stating: "How do you do it? You shake it! You shake that can! Teasing up your hair with your other hand!" and continuing with: "Hey girl! I have this dream when I close my eyes. I wish my hair was ten feet high!" As Anne Billson observed in her 1988 review of *Hairspray*:

Hairspray might almost be seen as genuinely subversive in that its optimistic tone, flirtation with the issues of civil rights, and refusal to subscribe to the 'less means more' philosophy, add up to what, these days, is a supremely unfashionable attitude." (Billson 1988)

This framing allows Waters to engage with the civil rights movement in a playful yet subversive manner, contrasting the film's camp sensibility with the serious issue of racial segregation.

The truly radical sub-text, however, is that a heroine can be politically motivated, a good dancer, attractive to the opposite sex, and fat all at the same time. (Billson 1988)

Despite its progressive messaging, the 1988 film is not without its limitations. Tracy, a white girl, plays the role of the “savior” in a struggle that perhaps should center the Black characters the struggle affects.

Across texts there are gradients of and variations on the white savior trope, but the overarching premise remains the same—a well-intentioned white character intervenes and typically saves a lower-class, urban, non-white character from whatever fate that character would have encountered were it not for their lucky encounter with the the film’s white messiah. (Deutsch 3)

This is not in contrast to *Hairspray* (2007) which adopts a more celebratory approach through musical numbers such as “You Can’t Stop the Beat” and “Run And Tell That” frame racial integration as an energetic, joyful inevitability rather than a deeply political struggle. The final number of the film, “You Can’t Stop the Beat,” puts aside all the racial tensions we have seen the entire film and gives Tracy a number to show her defeat against Amber. The catchy song springs the whole cast together as they sing. At first, Tracy is singing only with Link as Amber has a temper tantrum. However, in the middle of the song, Link pulls Inez (Maybelle’s daughter) into the show and in front of the camera. As Inez dances, society accepts her as they vote her from Miss Teen Hairspray beating both Amber and Tracey. This makes Inez the new lead dancer on the Corny Collins Show as Collins announces: “Ladies and gentleman, the Corny Collins Show is now and forever integrated!” As the general public of Baltimore are seen cheering. A Variety film review critiques this shift, noting that while the musical remains entertaining, it ultimately “softens” the civil rights narrative in favor of “Broadway/Hollywood- style inspirational uplift” (Harvey 2007).

This shift in focus is particularly evident in the character of Motormouth Maybelle. In the 1988 film, Maybelle (played by Ruth Brown) is a formidable black activist and leader of Corny Collin’s “Negro Day.” In the original film, Maybelle takes the lead in mobilizing resistance after “Negro Day” is canceled, delivering a passionate call to action:

Black Baltimore! Your mother is ready to show her might and fight! fight! fight! Alright, now after school you know where to go- Tildred Acres for the show! Segregation? No! No! No!

By contrast, in the 2007 adaptation, the idea for the protest is proposed by Tracy. Maybelle throws a party that was to announce the end of “Negro day.” When she does, everyone at the party (including dancers from “Negro day”) are all flabbergasted. Maybelle then gives a wildly different speech than that of the 1988 version. She tells the crowd:

Velma Von Tussle just told me we had our last show. It seems like our show was a nice little placeholder when it was time to get some ratings. I didn't want to tell y'all up front. I just wanted to have a little fun at night.

Tracey doesn't understand how the show could come to an end: “You can't have your own show? Fine! Come dance with us.” When Maybelle's son, Seaweed, explains to her that “blacks and whites have never danced on television before” Tracy responds with: “If we can't dance- Maybe we should just march.” As Alex Plant argues, the remake perpetuates a white- centered narrative by having Tracy, rather than Maybelle, initiate the protest march.

The main protest in the film is a civil rights march through Baltimore, which is proposed by Tracy upon hearing that Negro Day has been canceled. [The viewer] gets the impression this idea had never occurred to Maybelle before. This is simply unbelievable, and it is not clear why this should be the case considering the protest in the original film was in fact Maybelle's idea. Once again, it is the subtle changes in this film from the original which reinforce the stereotypes and white- centrism, as well as the promotion of an individual over a community. (Plant 8)

This transfer of agency from Maybelle to Tracy reflects the reinforcement of the white savior narrative, downplaying the role of Black activism in the civil rights movement and making racial justice seem like the result of individual goodwill rather than collective struggle. The 2007 version

reshapes the story in a way that is more comfortable but less politically engaged, shifting the focus from a community fighting for change to a single white protagonist leading the way.

The portrayal of Edna Turnblad, Tracy's mother, further reflects shifting cultural attitudes between the two versions of *Hairspray*. Edna is a plus sized woman, sassy, and insecure. While her depiction changes quite a bit between the versions of *Hairspray* two things remain the same: in both she is overweight and she is played by a man in drag.

The role of Edna Turnblad calls for a male actor in drag: Divine in the original film and John Travolta in the remake. Cross-dressing thus creates a double identity for "Edna" as both a female character suffering from her lack of conventional beauty and a male actor who comically simulates that formal failure. (Steiner 189)

In *Hairspray* (1988), Edna is played by Divine, a drag queen and longtime John Waters collaborator (Porter 9). Divine's exaggerated performance challenges traditional notions of womanhood, embracing a camp aesthetic that aligns with Waters' subversive vision.

To understand the image of Divine, one must first understand what is meant by "tacky drag." Tacky drag is essentially a deviation of the glamour ideal. The word "tacky" [meaning] cheap, shoddy, or of poor quality. (Porter 42)

The film's deliberate use of camp and irony resists a straightforward nostalgic idealization of the past, making Edna's portrayal a rejection of the mainstream, hyper-feminized ideals of womanhood. Susan Sontag describes camp as a sensibility that revels in artifice, exaggeration, and theatricality (Sontag 53), all of which are embodied in Divine's Edna. In one scene, after Tracy is accepted to be a dancer on the Corny Collins Show, 1988 Edna takes Tracy shopping. They both walked out in new dresses. Edna- who up until this point in the film only wore large smocks that hid her body- is now wearing a tight flowery dress, pearls, and sporting a new beehive hairdo. Edna's new look is exaggerated and theatrical, deliberately playing into and amplifying conventions of femininity rather than conforming to them. The styling, paired with

Divine's unapologetically campy performance, turns Edna into a caricature of domestic glamour, rejecting normative beauty standards and instead reveling in artificiality. Through this transformation, the film uses camp aesthetics to mock and reclaim hyper- feminized ideals, highlighting the absurdity of societal expectations placed on women, especially plus- sized women. Rather than presenting Edna's femininity as "earned" through weight loss or conformity, the film celebrates her body as it is, and her fashion makeover becomes a rebellion against shame. Edna's makeover, rather than signaling a reintegration into mainstream femininity, becomes a flamboyant, subversive performance that challenges the audience's assumptions. It's not a return to the past, but a rewriting of it—fitting with the film's overall use of nostalgia as a site of critique rather than comfort.

However, in the 2007 version, Edna is played by John Travolta in a performance that is more sentimental than subversive. In a 2007 film review, Hiram Lee critiques this shift, noting that Travolta's Edna is "surprisingly timid" compared to Divine's version, requiring Tracy to coax her into leaving their home and going into the outside world (Lee 2007). This change reflects a broader mainstreaming of *Hairspray*, making it more palatable for a family- friendly audience but losing some of its original edge. Instead of embodying camp as an act of resistance, Travolta's Edna is softened into a more conventional maternal figure and given a fear of leaving the home, reinforcing traditional gender norms rather than challenging them.

Comparative Analysis of Tone, Music, and Nostalgia

One of the key distinctions between the two versions of *Hairspray* lies in their tone and use of nostalgia. John Waters' *Hairspray* (1988) employs camp and irony to deconstruct mainstream nostalgia, exposing the contradictions of a supposedly progressive 1960s America. In contrast, *Hairspray* (2007) repackages the story as a high-energy musical spectacle that aligns with the conventions of feel-good Hollywood productions, ultimately neutralizing much of the original film's subversive elements. As Benson-Allott argues, the 1988 *Hairspray* both participates in and critiques nostalgia, revealing "the depoliticizing impulses that drive it" while using camp to encourage audiences to recognize the constructed nature of historical memory (Benson-Allott 143).

Although the 1988 film appears to align with progressive politics, Waters himself undercuts the idea that it was ever intended as an activist project. In an interview, he stated: "How brave was it to be a pro-civil rights movie in 1987? To say yes, I think blacks should be allowed to dance on television—it's not a real tough position to take" (Haspel 32). This remark emphasizes the film's irony and refusal to moralize, reinforcing its tone as one of irreverent parody rather than didacticism.

Waters' original film embraces camp aesthetics not only to entertain but also to challenge idealized notions of the past. Camp, as Susan Sontag describes, is a "failed seriousness" that operates by exaggeration and excess, turning what is supposed to be sincere into something self-aware and playful (Sontag 62). Waters, a filmmaker deeply rooted in the underground and queer cinema traditions, leverages camp to expose the absurdity of 1960s segregation, body politics, and television culture. Despite the camp nature of his film, as noted by Benson-Allott, it does not actively critique civil rights history, positioning Tracy's rise to fame as an ironic subversion of the very nostalgia it appears to celebrate.

Hairspray will not hold still and allow one to read it as “the remembrance of history as the past,” in other words, but respectfully requests analysis as one component of Waters’ negotiation with a specific episode in American history—a challenge to both camp and nostalgia’s alleged disinterest in real history. (Benson-Allott 146).

In contrast, *Hairspray* (2007) smooths out these jagged edges, embracing a more sanitized, albeit theatrical, vision of the past. The film transforms Waters’ rough, indie-film into a polished Broadway-inspired production, ultimately aligning itself more with mainstream commercial cinema than with Waters’ original countercultural vision. As a result, while the film retains the integration narrative, it does so in a way that feels more celebratory than critical. This is especially clear in the musical numbers.

As Amosi Morgan notes, musicals as a form “have the power to shift the perspectives of other people and ourselves. Musicals can be an inspiration or offer a prospect of an attainable future” (Morgan 18). The 2007 version leans into this inspirational potential, replacing irony with earnest optimism. Its vibrant, tightly choreographed numbers deliver a hopeful, harmonized vision of social change—one that reinforces progress as feel-good entertainment rather than political confrontation.

Music plays a central role in shaping nostalgia in both films, but each version approaches it differently. The 1988 *Hairspray* features authentic 1960s sounds, drawing from period-appropriate R&B, doo-wop, and dance music to immerse audiences in the historical moment. This soundtrack selection reinforces the film’s engagement with the past as a lived, contested reality rather than a mere aesthetic backdrop. Carol Flinn notes that music has the unique ability to “take you back,” creating emotional resonance tied to personal and collective memory. “There is a certain currency to the idea that music can ‘take you back’ — radio capitalizes on this with ‘oldies’ programs; entire films devote themselves to it.” (Flinn 19) Waters weaponizes this emotional pull by juxtaposing upbeat tunes with grotesque or absurd visuals, turning sentimentality into satire.

Conversely, *Hairspray* (2007) updates the music to fit the Broadway musical format, altering its historical specificity. Amosi Morgan argues that this shift reflects a broader trend in musical adaptations, where films are repackaged for contemporary audiences rather than critically examined. The transformation of *Hairspray* into a Broadway-style musical, complete with orchestrated dance numbers and show-stopping ballads, positions it within the lineage of Hollywood musicals that use historical settings as vibrant but ultimately decontextualized backdrops for entertainment. This approach, while engaging, risks diluting the film's historical commentary, replacing the urgency of racial struggle with a more universal and palatable message of inclusion.

This musical structure also lends itself to what Thomas Leitch identifies as “restorative nostalgia,” which is especially evident in Hollywood musicals. These films present “timeless song and dance numbers that convey the characters’ deepest emotions, desires, hopes, and fears,” offering an escape from timebound political tensions (Leitch 8). While Waters used music to clash with and comment on the period, the 2007 film uses it to soften historical memory into emotional spectacle. A prime example of this is the number “Run and Tell That,” performed by Seaweed and Inez. He invites Tracy and Penny to a dance in his neighborhood to which Tracy happily replies: “We are invited to places by colored people! We are so hip!” During the musical number, rather than portraying the systemic injustices and hardships faced by the community, the sequence bursts with vibrant choreography, and celebratory lyrics that emphasize pride and resilience but largely sidestep structural critique. Seaweed sings:

I can't see why people look at me and only see the color of my face. And then there's those that try to help. God knows, but always have to put me in my place. But I won't ask you to be color blind 'cause if you pick the fruit, then girl, you're sure to find... The blacker the berry the sweeter the juice

The upbeat tone and joyful presentation flatten the historical weight of segregation, transforming a potentially radical statement into an entertaining showcase. As such, the number functions more

as an invitation to feel good about diversity than to interrogate the real barriers to racial equity, further highlighting the film's prioritization of spectacle over sustained political engagement. When little Inez sings: "The people 'round here can barely pay their rent. They're trying to make a dollar out of fifteen cents. But we got a spirit money just can't buy" it is not presented as a devastation the black community of Baltimore faces but rather a celebration of resilience.

The film's choreography reflects this same dynamic. In a detailed study of choreography performance, Lidbury notes that characters in *Hairspray* (2007) are choreographed along distinct racial lines:

[White characters] move with specific movement qualities - bound flow and light energy - on straight pathways with direct movements at middle and high levels [...] while the 'coloured people' would move predominantly with stronger energy, on curving and circular pathways with indirect movements at middle and low levels mostly in the floating plane. The exception was Tracy who naturally moved in this latter way which, fortunately, was right, for the narrative demands that she move like Seaweed and the other black kids; this way of moving draws Corny Collins' attention to her but contributes to the Council members despising her. When 'integration' was achieved in the final number movement material was shared with all the characters dancing each other's material. (Lidbury 13)

Tracy's ability to "naturally move" like the Black dancers marks her as exceptional and desirable—earning her a spot on the show while making her an object of scorn among her white peers such as Velma. This symbolic integration through movement culminates in the finale song as "all the characters [are] dancing each other's material," visually reinforcing a harmonious post-racial fantasy that depoliticizes integration.

Nostalgia, as Fredric Jameson argues, often operates as a form of pastiche, stripping historical moments of their political depth in favor of stylized representation (Jameson 68). In *Hairspray* (1988), Waters acknowledges this tendency but actively subverts it by making the film's

campiness a tool for critique. By contrast, *Hairspray* (2007) exemplifies what Jameson describes as the commodification of nostalgia, transforming the 1960s setting into a consumable aesthetic rather than a site of historical struggle.

Leitch expands this idea, noting that American nostalgia tends to be visual and spatial—fixated on “idealized or sentimental dreams” rather than historically grounded journeys (Leitch 8). The 2007 film reflects this through its slick, spectacular portrayal of Baltimore, which becomes less a city than a backdrop for inclusive choreography and optimistic tunes.

The 2007 film’s high-energy finale, “You Can’t Stop the Beat,” encapsulates this approach, presenting racial integration as a joyous, inevitable achievement rather than a contested historical process. The film thus embodies what Morgan calls the “entertainment activism paradox” of musicals: they offer catharsis and uplift, but often at the expense of real historical or political complexity (Morgan 19). By wrapping the narrative in a triumphant spectacle, the film risks erasing the very tensions it seeks to address.

Conclusion

In conclusion, both *Hairspray* films- John Waters' 1988 original and Adam Shankman's 2007 remake- offer more than stylistic variations on the same narrative. They reveal the ideological fault lines within American nostalgia and present two different relationships to history. Each film uses memory in its own way: one to interrogate the contradictions of the past, the other to smooth them over in a harmonized vision of progress. Through these contrasting uses of nostalgia, these films articulate how cinema does not reflect history but reshapes and curates it, guiding collective memory according to the emotional and political climates of the moment.

Waters' *Hairspray* refuses to make the past feel comfortable. Rooted in camp, drag, and satire, the 1988 film offers a critique not only of the 1960s, but of the Reagan- era 1980s nostalgia boom that sought to restore a sanitized, whitewashed image of post- war America. Waters' vision of the 1960s is grotesque, joyful, and subversive- intentionally tacky as a rejection of aesthetic polish and ideological neatness. Through its humor and exaggerated aesthetic, the film creates a kind of "reflective nostalgia," which, as Paul Frosh describes, does not yearn for a return to the past but instead invites audiences to interrogate it. This version of *Hairspray* makes it impossible to take the past at face value. It forces viewers to see that our cultural memory is always constructed.

The film's political work lies not in its plot resolution but in its tonal tension. While the story concludes with racial integration on the Corny Collins Show, the journey there is absurd and awkward, exposing how superficial such progress can be. Waters critiques not only the history of segregation but the media's tendency to oversimplify and sanitize that history. Tracy Turnblad, the white teen protagonist, may be the vehicle for change, but her status as a savior figure is steeped in irony. Her outsized heroism reads as both ridiculous and poignant, simultaneously mocking the trope of the white liberal savior and revealing how much society depends on it.

In contrast, Shankman's 2007 *Hairspray* offers nostalgia as comfort. It embraces "restorative nostalgia"—a longing for the past that aims to recapture an idealized version of it. Set to a

Broadway musical beat, the film recasts the civil rights struggle as spectacle, resolving structural racism through choreography, ballads, and romantic subplots. Tracy remains the protagonist and again leads the charge toward integration, but now without the subversive irony. Her journey is earnest, triumphant, and digestible. And therein lies the issue: the messiness of history is rewritten as a sing-along narrative of progress, in which racism is embodied by cartoonish villains and eliminated by individual courage. This remake also diminishes the roles of Black characters from the original. Motormouth Maybelle, who in the original film leads the charge for justice, becomes a supportive maternal figure. The 2007 version of the protest march was initiated not by her, but by Tracy. This is a subtle but significant shift that recenters white agency in a story that should foreground Black resistance.

Yet, it would be unfair to ignore the emotional appeal of the 2007 version. Its optimism is contagious. Its music, choreography, and energy present a world where barriers fall easily, where joy itself is revolutionary. But the question remains: at what cost is this vision achieved? If optimism simplifies injustice, and if joy becomes a substitute for historical reality, then what is being celebrated? Progress without struggle becomes fantasy and nostalgia becomes an ideological tool of erasure.

These two films demonstrate how the media creates frameworks for understanding the past and thus, for understanding the present. In Waters' version, memory is contested, unstable, and absurd. In Shankman's, it is celebratory, streamlined, and easily consumed. Both reflect the political conditions of their production. The 1988 film arrives at the close of a conservative decade obsessed with reclaiming a mythologized America; the 2007 film is born into an era of branding diversity and commercializing inclusivity. Together, they expose how nostalgia can be wielded to question history or to rewrite it.

This seminar has argued that neither version of *Hairspray* should be seen as merely entertainment. Each film makes ideological choices about how to represent race, history, and activism. By situating both within their cultural moments, we see how cinema not only reflects collective

memory but actively constructs it. Both films are useful, both are revealing, and both are political. The challenge is to recognize when nostalgia opens space for critique and when it serves as a distraction.

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